Meditations for a Savage Child

By Adrienne Rich

INTRODUCTION

In a world where language and naming are power, silence is oppression. Silence is violence. It is an identity in agony, screaming but not heard – and the scar is visible mark – "a hieroglyph for a scream." In Meditations for a Savage Child, Adrienne Rich compares a feral child struggling to adapt to an alien society of words and expectations to her own struggle as a female poet to use the limited language available to express her savage thoughts in a male-dominated world. Meditations for a Savage Child by Adrienne Rich.

(Prose passages are from J-M Itard's account of The Wild Boy of Aveyron, as translated by G. and M. Humphrey)

I.

There was a profound indifference to the objects of our pleasures and of our fictitious needs; there was still . . . so intense a passion for the freedom of the fields . . . that he would certainly have escaped into the forest had not the most rigid precautions been taken . . .

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In their own way, by their own lights
they tried to care for you
tried to teach you to care
for objects of their caring:
glossed oak planks, glass
whirled in a fire
to impossible thinness
to teach you names
for things
you did not need
muslin shirred against the sun
linen on a sack of feathers
locks, keys
boxes with coins inside
they tried to make you feel
the importance of
a piece of cowhide
sewn around a bundle
of leaves impressed with signs
to teach you language:

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the thread their lives

were strung on

II

When considered from a more general and philosophic point of view, these scars bear witness . . . against the feebleness and insufficiency of man when left entirely to himself, an in favor of the resources of nature which . . . work openly to repair and conserve that which she tends secretly to impair and destroy.

I keep thinking about the lesson of the human ear

which stands for music, which stands for balance --

or the cat's ear which I can study better

the whorls and ridges exposed

It seems a hint dropped about the inside of the skull

which I cannot see

lobe, zone, that part of the brain

which is pure survival

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The most primitive part

I go back into at night

pushing the leathern curtain

with naked fingers

then

with naked body

There where every wound is registered

as scar tissue

A cave of scars!

ancient, archaic wallpaper

built up, layer on layer

from the earliest, dream-white

to yesterday's, a red-black scrawl

a red mouth slowly closing

Go back so far there is another language

go back far enough the language

is no longer personal

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these scars bear witness

but whether to repair

or to destruction

I no longer know.

III

It is true that there is visible on the throat a very extended scar which might throw some doubt upon the soundness of the underlying parts if one were not reassured by the appearance of the scar . . .

When I try to speak

my throat is cut

And, it seems, by his hand

The sounds I make are prehuman, radical

the telephone is always

ripped-out

and he sleeps on

Yet always the tissue

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grows over, white as silk

hardly a blemish

maybe a hieroglyph for scream

Child, no wonder you never wholly

trusted your keepers

IV

A hand with the will rather than the habit of crime had wished to make an attempt on the life of this child . . . left for dead in the woods, he will have owed the prompt recover of his wound to the help of nature alone.

In the 18th century infanticide

reaches epidemic proportions:

old prints attest to it: starving mothers

smothering babies in sleep

abandoning newborns in sleet

on the poorhouse steps

gin-blurred, setting fire to the room

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I keep thinking of the flights we used to take

on the grapevine across the gully

littered with beer-bottles where dragonflies flashed

we were 10, 11 years old

wild little girls with boyish bodies

flying over the moist

shadow-mottled earth

till they warned us to stay away from there

Later they pointed out

the venetian blinds

of the abortionist's house

we shivered

Men can do things to you

was all they said.

V

And finally, my Lord, looking at this long experiment . . . whether it be considered as the methodical education of a savage or as no more than the physical and moral treatment of one of those creatures ill-favored by

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nature, rejected by society and abandoned by medicine, the care that has been taken and ought still to be taken of him, the changes that have taken place, and those that can be hoped for, the voice of humanity, the interest inspired by such a desertion and a destiny so strange – all these things recommend this extraordinary young man to the attention of scientists, to the solicitude of administrators, and to the protection of the government.

1. The doctor in "uncle Vanya":

They will call us fools,

blind, ignorant, they will

despise us.

devourers of the forest

leaving teeth of metal in every tree

so the tree can neither grow

nor be cut for lumber

Does the primeval forest

weep

for its devourers

does nature mourn

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our existence

is the child with arms

burnt to the flesh of its sides

weeping eyelessly for man

2. At the end of the distinguished doctor's

lecture

a young woman raises her hand:

You have the power

in your hands, you control our lives --

why do you want our pity too?

Why are men afraid

why do you pity yourselves

why do the administrators

lack solicitude, the government

refuse protection,

why should the wild child

weep for the scientists

why

SOURCE INFORMATION

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